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NAMING THE MIND

Alternative psychologies

Many years ago, before Kuhnian paradigms had ever been heard of, I spent two years teaching Psychology at an Indonesian university. When I arrived to take up my duties, I discovered that a course on Psychology was already being taught by one of my Indonesian colleagues. But whereas my subject matter was identified on the timetable as *Psychologi*, his was identified by the Indonesian equivalent, *ilmu djiwa*, 'djiwa' meaning 'soul' or 'psyche', and 'ilmu' being a science or an '-ology' of some kind. So there was a literal local equivalent of 'psychology', but I was not the one scheduled to teach it. I soon found out why. What my colleague was teaching was not Western psychology, but something based on an extensive local literature that had roots in Hindu philosophy with Javanese additions and reinterpretations. So the students had a choice of two psychologies, one Western and one Eastern.

At the time, that struck me as odd. After all, if both my Indonesian colleague and I were dealing with psychological reality, there ought to be some points of contact, even convergence, between our domains. Certainly, our ways of approaching this reality were very different, but that difference might perhaps be used constructively, if we could combine the strong features of both approaches. So I rashly suggested to my colleague that we consider offering joint seminars in which each of us would explain our approach to the same set of psychological topics, followed by an analysis of our differences. Very politely, he agreed to my proposal, and we sat down to discuss the topics we would cover in such a seminar. That is where the problems began. There seemed to be virtually no topics that were identified as such both in his and in my psychology.

For instance, I wanted to discuss the topic of motivation and was interested in hearing what theories my colleague might offer about how motives operated and developed. But he said that would be quite difficult for him, because from his point of view motivation was not really a topic. The phenomena that I quite spontaneously grouped together as 'motivational' seemed to him to be no more than a heterogeneous collection of things that had nothing interesting in common.